Old Scars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50711698.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Implied/Referenced Self-Harm, One Shot, Hurt/Comfort

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by gayusernamegoeshere

Summary

After the war was over, the Rebellion returned to their old base to celebrate, but Catra and Adora slipped off by themselves. As she bandaged Adora's wounds, Catra noticed a series of scars on Adora's arm she had never seen before.

Mere hours after the defeat of Horde Prime, Adora stood in front of the mirror in the rebellion's base in the Whispering Woods. Her hand moved to her chest where the failsafe's glow had been replaced by a scarred outline of the words. It was strange how quickly things had changed. Just last night Adora had been standing in this exact place before setting out to deploy the failsafe and hopefully not die in the process. She smiled exhaustedly at her disheveled reflection.

They had won

The war was over.

Adora turned to the main room where the rebellion was celebrating with Hordak and a few Horde soldiers. Mermista and Perfuma were doling out rations with reckless abandon. And Bow had already picked up his violin to play an up-beat if slightly off-key tune, Glimmer smiling and laughing next to him. Adora breathed in the scene and smiled, happy to see all her friends safe and celebrating. They deserved it.

Catra slipped into the alcove with Adora, a flower lei from Perfuma draped around her neck. She collapsed on her cot.

Catra let out a breath. "You rebellion types sure know how to party."

Adora smiled, albeit weakly.

Catra noticed and sat up, "Is everything okay? What are you doing lurking in here? People are looking for you."

"Sorry," Adora shook her head lightly, "The whole thing just feels so surreal. I mean…" she sat down, her sore muscles aching, "our whole lives we've been trained to fight in this war, and now it's over?" She let out a tense breath. "I guess I just don't know what comes next."

Catra laid back and closed her eyes, “I’m not sure. But we’ll figure it out, as long as we’re together.” She opened one eye and peeked at Adora as she referenced the old memory.

Adora smiled gently at the familiar words. “You promise?”

Catra laughed, “Of course, you dummy.” She punched Adora in the side.

Adora winced as she hit the wound from earlier.

Catra sat up, “ooh sorry” she peeked worriedly at Adora’s side. “Did it not heal?”

“The virus went away when we deployed the failsafe, but it’s still cut.” Adora squirmed away from Catra’s concern “I’m fine. It’s not deep”

Catra scoffed, “ Come on, you don’t have to pretend with me.”

“You're one to talk.”

Catra laughed and stood up, walking to the crates against the wall and pulling out a first aid kit.

She sat back down next to Adora, pulling out some bandages. “Shirt. Off. Now.”

Adora raised an eyebrow at Catra, who turned bright red. Adora laughed and complied.

Catra treated and bandaged the wound with surprisingly gentle hands. Adora let her shoulders drop, melting into Catra’s soft touch.

She had missed her.

Catra finished and let her hands wander up to Adora’s back. She traced the scars from the Battle of Bright Moon, her fingers perfectly lining up with the healed claw marks.

Catra didn’t say anything but Adora thought she heard a sniffle. She smiled sadly, “It’s okay Catra, it was a while ago, things have changed… you’ve changed.”

Catra didn't react, but instead shifted to touch a series of scars on Adora’s upper arm. A tear fell from the end of her nose and slipped down Adora’s bicep. “Were these from me as well?”

Adora tensed, staring at the innocent pink lines on her skin. Just a look at them could never tell their story. Tears sprung to her own eyes now.

Catra’s eyes widened. “Oh, I’m sorry, did I say something wrong. I shouldn’t have asked—“

“It’s okay.” Adora cut her off. She considered lying. It would be so much easier than telling the truth. She put her hand over the scars, fingernails digging into her skin. “No, those weren’t you.” Adora squeezed her eyes shut. If they were going to make this work she had to be honest. Still, this was something she had never told anyone and had planned to keep a secret forever. She almost smiled at the irony, she could destroy bots in seconds and face intergalactic horrors with a brave face but now she was terrified trying to talk to her girlfriend. “Those weren’t you” she repeated almost inaudibly. “It was me.” She paused for a moment trying and failing to keep her emotions in check. Catra remained quiet, giving her the time to think.

“After I broke the sword, when you and Glimmer got kidnapped… it was a dark time for the rebellion, and for me.” Adora closed her eyes, lost in the memories until she felt Catra touch her hand. Adora looked up. Catra’s eyebrows were knit together in concern. She let out a low purring sound, letting Adora know she was there for her. Adora grabbed her hand, “Without She-ra’s powers, I felt useless. Everyone was constantly reminding me about my limitations.” She sighed “They were just trying to keep me from doing something stupid—“

“As you tend to do”

“but it was embarrassing and hurtful.” Adora ignored Catra’s snipe. “At least I knew we were helping people. Until…”

Adora’s shoulders dropped and Catra squeezed her hand. Adora took strength in her support and continued, “One day a mission went wrong. It was just me. I was trying to evacuate a village and we didn’t think we would need many fighters. But the Horde bots found us.” Adora swallowed hard, “Before I realized what was happening half the village was dead.” She had to pause and let her voice come back. “I got everyone else out of there, but it wasn’t good enough. People lost friends and family because of me. I was the one who said I could handle the mission alone. It was my fault and mine alone.” Catra chuffed beside her but Adora was on a roll and didn’t pause to decode Catra’s displeasure. “Maybe if I had brought more soldiers we could have saved them. Or if I had still had the sword I could have prevented it.” Even now, Adora was furious with herself. She would never forget the screams as people realized what was happening. “When we got back to base, I lost it. I should have helped the wounded but I couldn’t bear to see their pain. The pain I should have prevented. I broke down. I hid in my tent, grabbed a knife and…” she rubbed the lines on her arm.

Adora turned to Catra. Her multicolored eyes were wet with tears. Adora thought she noticed a hint of frustration in the tilt of Catra’s eyes, that scared her more than she would like to admit so Adora kept talking, “I think, in the moment, I wanted to hurt myself because I thought it was what I deserved. I caused other people pain so I deserved to feel pain of my own.” She still felt like that sometimes, despite having She-ra back. With everyone around her supporting her it was getting better. “That wasn’t the first time. Or the last” She gestured at several more lines on her other arm, some still scabbing over. “I just put my jacket on and no one ever knew.” She looked over at Catra “Until now.”

Catra was silent. Adora bit her lip; she half expected Catra to start laughing, but instead she just slowly shifted and rolled up her pant leg revealing lines matching the claw marks on Adora’s back.

“Here’s mine.” She finally said, using little words the way Catra frequently did when it came to emotional things.

Adora didn’t know what to say either. Growing up in the Horde, where emotions were considered weakness, they had never gotten a chance to learn how to express themselves.

So Adora trusted actions over words. She raked her fingers into Catra’s short tangled hair and pulled her into their second ever kiss.

The last time they kissed, Adora had been dying, the world had been ending. Their lips had met with the passion and sadness of all the years they lost.

This kiss felt softer. Warmer. Like the promise of a life together yet to come.

Adora was so focused on the feeling of Catra’s lips on hers, their bodies intertwining, that she didn’t notice Bow pull open the curtain of the alcove.

He jumped and shielded his eyes, “Whoa get a room you guys!”

He turned to leave but Catra jumped to explain. “I was just bandaging her wound Arrow Boy, get your mind out of the gutter!”

“Did Adora get a cut on her tongue!” He stumbled back to the party, red faced.

Adora and Catra met eyes before collapsing in giggles.

As they stopped laughing, Adora breathed out a final question, “So, you’re not mad at me?”

Catra shot her a look, “Really Adora? We just made out, and you’re still asking me if I'm mad?”

As they spoke, Adora reached for Catra's ankle which was also still injured from the Heart. Catra must have been feeling generous because she let Adora bandage it without complaint.

"You just made a weird face, and it was a huge mistake on my part that other people paid the price for—" Carta pinched her arm, hard. "What was that for?" Adora clutched her arm.

"Stop it." Catra's words were clipped and matter-of-fact. Adora furrowed her brow. She didn't understand. "Stop blaming yourself. You didn't kill those people, so you are not responsible for their deaths. Prime is."

Adora opened her mouth to argue but Catra cut her off, "Nope. No arguing. Let me finish." Catra took a deep breath as if steeling herself for her next words. Her ears dropped as her voice quavered slightly, but her eyes remained determined. "Do I deserve pain for everything I've done? For all the ways I hurt you?"

"No! Of course not!" Adora practically shouted it. Daring anyone to argue with her.

Catra smiled softly, "Then neither do you. You didn't even hurt people, you did your best to save them!"

But what if my best isn't good enough?

Adora closed her eyes and tried to focus on Catra's hand in hers, ignoring the thoughts swirling through her mind. She could deal with those another time.

"I'll try." Adora said, her free hand tracing some of the lines on Catra's calf. "We'll both try?"

Catra nodded and leaned her forehead on Adora's

"I promise."

Adora pecked Catra on the cheek before reaching for her shirt and shoving it back over her shoulders. “Come on Catra,” Adora stood up and offered a hand to Catra. “we should join the others before Glimmer comes in here to yell at us for the PDA”

Catra laughed that wonderful laugh of hers, “She wouldn’t, her and Arrow Boy have been all over each other all night!” She took Adora’s hand and pulled herself up, her flowers hanging crooked around her neck.

Adora tilted her head and raised an eyebrow, “You don’t know her like I do.” The two girls shared a final private moment before entering into the joy and noise of the main room. Catra pulled Adora out of their little alcove, and Adora caught a last glance at herself in the mirror as they plunged into the celebration.

It looked like things were going to be okay.

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